

PROBLEM:

Factors involved:
national security problem;
It is the purpose of this study to determine what concern to CIA, if
are present
any, is ~~resident~~ in the problem of "unidentified flying objects," and to recommend,
solve the problem
if such interest is found, steps that should be taken to improve CIA's intelligence
and lessen the risks.
~~position on subjects related to national security.~~

FACTS BEARING ON THE PROBLEM:

1. Since 1947, there have been about 1500 official reports of sightings plus an enormous volume of letters, phone calls and press reports. During this July alone, official reports totaled 250. Of the 1500, Air Force carries 20% as unexplained and of those received since the first of this year, 28% unexplained.
2. The administrative unit now handling the Air Force inquiry on these phenomena is a small section headed by an Air Force Reserve Captain, E. J. Ruppelt, assisted by two lieutenants and two secretaries at Air Technical Intelligence Center, Wright Field. It is from this small group that the controlling collection directive to the entire Air Force originated and it is to this small group that the flood of reports on flying saucers comes for collation and analysis.
3. Research and analysis at this time is limited almost exclusively to the

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The three man OSI team entered into its inquiry fully aware that it was entering into a field already charged with partisanship, one in which objectivity had been overridden by numerous sensational writers, and one in which there are pressures for extravagant explanations as well as for oversimplification. They consulted with a representative of Air Force Special ^{Studies} ~~Projects~~ group; discussed the problem with those in charge of the Air Force Project at Wright field; reviewed a considerable volume of intelligence reports; checked the Soviet press and broadcast indices; and conferred with three of our consultants at MIT, all leaders in their scientific fields.

The present small scale inquiry at ATIC, which thus far has been able only to use the case history approach, examining each incident carefully to determine whether it can be explained or whether it must be put into the "unexplained" category, was considered a perfectly valid procedure but one that offered but little chance in opening up explanations regarding the nature of these phenomena. As MIT told us, it would probably be found on the margins or just outside of our present knowledge in the fields of atmospheric, ionospheric, and geophysical phenomena, taking into account the possibility of a man-made factor to consider. A systematic approach to the problem would contemplate a centrally coordinated and a number of fronts and involving a variety of

CONFIDENTIAL

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The problem of "unidentified flying objects" is a national security problem of concern to operations as well as to intelligence.

2. Operational problems are of primary importance and should be attacked at once. They include:

a. Taking immediate steps to improve identification of "phantoms" so that in the event of an attack, instant and positive identification of enemy rockets or plans could be made.

b. Determination of what if any utilization should be made of these phenomena by US psychological warfare planners and what, if any, defenses should be planned in anticipation of Soviet attempts to utilize them.

3. Intelligence problems include.

a. Knowledge of the exact nature of these phenomena especially as regards:

(1) Whether any are susceptible to control, and can be thus utilized for either military or psychological offense or defense.

(2) Whether any are predictable and can thus be taken advantage of in military or psychological operations.

b. The present level of Russian knowledge regarding these phenomena.

c. Possible Soviet intentions and capabilities to utilize these phenomena to the detriment of US security interests.

d. The reasons for silence in the Soviet Press regarding "flying saucers".

4. Intelligence responsibilities in this field as regards both collection and analysis can be discharged with maximum effectiveness only after much more

~~SECRET~~

The problem transcends the boundaries of individual departmental responsibilities, and is of such importance as to merit cognizance and action by the National Security Council.

6. Additional work, differing in character and emphasis from that presently under way will be required to meet the specific needs in this field of both operations and intelligence.

RECOMMENDATIONS:

One of the two possible courses of action set forth below is proposed; one requires NSC action, and the other requires action by Secretary of Defense:

1. NSC action: under this course, it is recommended:

a. That the DCI present to the NSC a draft NSC directive (TAB A) which prescribes that a centrally administered research program under RDS be established, in accordance with Sec. 214 (a), National Security Act of 1947, this program having for its research objectives requirements to be specified by the Secretary of Defense; the Director of Central Intelligence, and Director Psychological Strategy Board.

b. That upon issuance of this NSC directive, CIA exercise its functions by providing coordinated intelligence requirements and intelligence support to RDS.

2. Secretary of Defense action: under this course, it is recommended:

a. That the DCI act to Secretary of Defense along lines of the recommendation that coordinated research program would be available to CIA, and that a study is undertaken by Defense, that coordinated intelligence support be provided by CIA before the study is started.

DRAFT

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NSC

SUBJECT: Unidentified flying objects.

1. The National Security Council has recognized as a national security problem our present limited capabilities in making prompt positive visual or mechanical identification of flying objects. The problem is recognized also as one which bears directly upon both offensive and defensive capabilities of the armed forces; as one of concern to operations as well as to intelligence; and as one having possible implications for psychological warfare.

2. As the nature of the problem is such that a centrally administered inquiry rather than a divided effort offers the best promise of progress, the Director, Research and Development Board is charged with the responsibility of administering in this field a program of research which meets the specifications of Secretary of Defense and as regards operational requirements; of the Director of Central Intelligence, as regards the intelligence requirements and of Director, Psychological Strategy Board, as regards psychological warfare implications.

DRAFT LETTER

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FROM: DCI

TO : Secretary of Defense

SUBJECT: Intelligence interest in a study of unidentified flying objects.

1. Recently CIA's Office of Scientific Intelligence made an inquiry into the possible intelligence implications of this subject. We concluded that while the operational problem of improvement in identification of "phantoms" was of first priority because of the need to make instant and positive identification of enemy rockets or planes, the solution of intelligence problems are of sufficient importance to justify vigorous support by this Agency of an organized attack on the problem.

2. In our inquiry three of our men consulted with a representative of Air Force Special Projects group; discussed the problem with those in charge of the Air Force Project at Wright field; reviewed a considerable volume of intelligence reports; checked the Soviet press and broadcast indices; and conferred with three of our consultants at MIT, all leaders in their scientific fields.

3. The present small scale inquiry at AFIC, which thus far has been able to use the case history approach, examining each incident carefully to determine whether it can be explained or whether it must be put into the category of "unexplained" is a perfectly valid procedure but one that provides in opening up explanations regarding the nature of these incidents at MIT told us, it would probably be found on the frontiers of our present knowledge in the fields

...phenomena, taking into account the possibility that nuclear waste products might also be a factor to consider.

A systematic attack on the as-yet unexplained cases would contemplate a centrally coordinator program involving projects on a number of fronts and involving a variety of techniques not now used.

4. As the strictly US military operations problem of improved identification at home and abroad is closely tied to a number of intelligence questions, it would be advantageous to CIA, as well as to the interests of the intelligence components of Department of Defense, if intelligence research requirements could be included in any organized inquiry into the subject.

5. At this time we know so little of the exact nature of these phenomena that additional research would be necessary before it could be said whether any are susceptible to control and can thus be utilized for either military or psychological offense or defense, or whether any are predictable, and can thus be taken advantage of in military or psychological operations.

6. It may be found that an appropriate center for such research would be in a group such as Project Lincoln which is now working for Department of Defense on problems of air defense.

7. At this time we are unable to find any basis in our information for ... to Soviet intentions or capabilities to utilize these phenomena to our detriment. The Soviet Press has been silent on the subject -- which is itself provocative -- and we are not yet able to appraise the present level of knowledge of Soviet scientists regarding these phenomena.

8. It would be appreciated if this agency could participate in any plans for further inquiry into this subject.

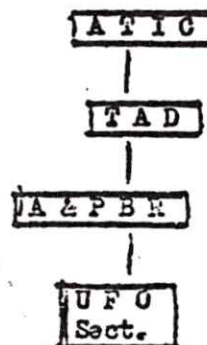
PRESENT STATUS OF THE INQUIRY

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[Mr. Strong has discussed with you some of the general features of this problem, and now I should like I am going to to describe briefly how the Air Force has organized its study of reports on unidentified flying objects and outline its methods.

The administrative unit now handling the Air Force inquiry on these phenomena is [the unidentified Flying Objects Section of the Aircraft Propulsion Branch of the Technical Analysis Division of Air Technical Intelligence Center, Wright Field.]



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[This] small section is headed by an Air Force Reserve Captain, E. J. Ruppelt, at Air Technical Intelligence Center, assisted by two lieutenants and two secretaries. It is from this small group that the controlling collection directive to the entire Air Force originated and it is to this small group that the flood of reports on unidentified-flying ^{flying saucers} objects comes for collation and analysis.

The strength and position of this central administrative group clearly indicates a low level of support, and, presumably, serious reservations in the Air Force regarding the value of extensive inquiry into the subject. Paradoxically

12

this central effort at ATIC is maintained on a minimal basis while there is concurrently ordered a world-wide reporting system and an interception program which may expend hundreds of man hours and thousands of dollars.

The methods used by Air Force are now in the process of change but the conclusions and explanations given to the public are based on the process I am going to describe.

Research and analysis at this time is limited almost exclusively to the case history method. Reports, which are limited in their coverage to ten broad elements of information, are received from the field, mainly through the Air-intelligence reporting system, though also to a limited extent from the other services and from the Department of State.

These reports come to the Unidentified Objects Section where each one are is examined separately to determine whether it is explainable as "misinterpretations of a known object", or whether it must be classed as "unexplained" and subject to further investigation.

In this sorting process, the reports are first examined in the light of established and readily available fact such as known balloon tracks or aircraft flights. The report may then be referred to an Air Force Base or to the Office